

online. The most recent sales price, year of construction, square footage, number of bathrooms and bedrooms, zoning information, and more are often contained in these records. (Call your local government or do a search on real property or tax administration to find the records.)

Is there a political component to tax values? I think so. Higher home values can mean higher property taxes (depending on assessment rates) and more money in the public treasury. Except when, perhaps, there is a public disincentive to increasing property values, say in a neighborhood where the state or municipality intends to acquire properties (or has in the past) by exercising eminent domain. For example, when I reported over \$40,000 in home improvements made by a licensed general contractor to my home (such as bringing the bathroom up to new building code, replacing vinyl flooring with ceramic tile, and ripping out pressed wood and installing maple cabinets), the tax assessor increased its value by \$0.

I haven't complained, of course, and plan to resist asking for a revaluation until I put my house on the market; for now, there is a 60+% differential between my home's tax-assessed value and Zillow.com's.

REAL (CERTIFIED) APPRAISALS

Real appraisals are performed by licensed or certified appraisers, regulated at the state level. To get an idea of the information they gather and analyze (either through full-home inspections or drive-by inspections of single-family homes), check out the Uniform Residential Appraisal Report.

Appraisers should have an understanding of housing market trends, including sales activity relating to specific neighborhoods. Knowing the value of certain features and amenities (number of bedrooms and full baths, in-ground pools, decks, patios, two-car garages) is especially useful for calculating replacement costs and figuring out adjustments based on differences for sales comparables, which is often the focus of the appraisal.

SALES COMPARABLES

Appraisers find residential properties that are comparable to your house (the subject property). In a large suburban development, that's usually pretty easy because several houses of similar size and construction type will often sell each year; in a rural area, it's trickier be-